

Handout: Reina Hayaki, “Fictional Characters as Abstract Objects: Some Questions”

The Problem and the Proposed UpShot

Hayaki’s paper targets **creationism** about fictional characters: the view that characters like *Sherlock Holmes* are **abstract artifacts** created by authors. This view is attractive because it seems to give us a real referent for fictional names and helps explain how later works can be *about the same character* (for instance, Holmes in Doyle, pastiche, parody, and criticism). But Hayaki argues that creationism is not without some issues. Once Holmes is treated as a real abstract object, creationists must say things that are deeply counterintuitive about **truth in fiction** and about what a fiction is **about**. The central problem, then, is that creationism appears to secure ontological benefits only by forcing a highly awkward semantics. (pp. 141–142)

Hayaki’s “solution” is not to give a full alternative theory of fictional characters. Rather, her conclusion is more critical and comparative: **creationism faces distinctive tensions**, especially when compared with rival views like **possibilism** and some versions of **Meinongianism**. Her aim is to show that creationists owe us a better explanation of these tensions, or else stronger compensating advantages elsewhere. (pp. 148–149)

1. Setup: The Holmes Case and the Attractions of Creationism (p. 141)

Hayaki begins with a series of seemingly obvious claims about Conan Doyle’s Sherlock Holmes stories:

- It is true according to the Canon that **Sherlock Holmes is a detective**.
- It is true according to the Canon that **Queen Victoria hired a detective**, gave him an emerald tiepin, and offered him a knighthood.
- The Canon is **about Sherlock Holmes**.
- The Canon is **about a brilliant private detective**.
- The Canon is **also about Queen Victoria**.

These claims look innocent, but Hayaki argues that together they generate trouble for the abstract-object view.

Why creationism is attractive

Creationism has two especially important attractions for Hayaki's discussion:

- **Semantic attraction:** if "Sherlock Holmes" refers to a real abstract object, then sentences containing the name do not involve empty names or "gappy propositions." This is especially attractive for **Millians**, who think names contribute only their referents to propositions. (p. 141)
- **Cross-fictional identity attraction:** if Holmes really exists as an abstract artifact, then later Holmes stories can literally be *about that very same object*. This helps with pastiche, parody, adaptation, and literary criticism. (pp. 141–142)

So the initial motivation for creationism is clear: it promises ontological seriousness and semantic neatness.

2. First Difficulty: Truth in Fiction and "Massive Falsity" (pp. 142–144)

Hayaki's first objection concerns the difference between statements about **real entities** in fiction and statements about **fictional entities** if the latter are abstract objects.

The asymmetry

Consider:

- **Queen Victoria** is real.
- **Sherlock Holmes**, on creationism, is also real—but abstract.

Now the Canon says false things about Queen Victoria: she did not actually hire Holmes. But that is familiar enough; fictions often misdescribe real people. (p. 142)

The real trouble is Holmes. If Holmes is an abstract object, then the Canon attributes to him properties radically incompatible with abstractness:

- being human
- being male
- being six feet tall
- smoking
- playing the violin
- being a detective

So if creationism is taken straightforwardly, the Canon is not just selectively false; it is "**massively false**" about Holmes and the other fictional characters. It presents abstract artifacts

as concrete people. Hayaki thinks this is a severe cost: it is one thing to say fiction inaccurately portrays Queen Victoria; it is another to say Doyle's stories are basically a cascade of falsehoods about abstract objects. (pp. 142–143)

Supplement: why this matters philosophically

This issue sits at the intersection of **metaphysics** and **philosophy of language**. The question is not merely whether Holmes exists, but **what kind of semantic relation** obtains between a fictional discourse and the object supposedly referred to. If creationism makes ordinary fictional predication into systematic misdescription, then its semantic gains may be illusory.

3. The Two-Tier Response and Its Cost (pp. 143–144)

Some creationists try to avoid the “massive falsity” problem by adopting a **two-tier view** of fictional names.

The two-tier strategy

On this view:

- **Outside** the fiction, “Sherlock Holmes” refers to an abstract object.
- **Inside** the fiction, “Sherlock Holmes” is **not referential at all**.

Hayaki discusses van Inwagen here. He introduces a primitive ternary relation, **A**: a property is *ascribed* to a fictional character in a fiction. This is meant to avoid saying that Doyle straightforwardly predicates detectivehood of an abstract object. (pp. 142–143)

But Hayaki presses the point: if Doyle, in writing the story, was not genuinely referring and not genuinely predicating, then what becomes of claims like:

- “It is true according to the Canon that Holmes is a detective”?
- “It is true according to the Canon that Queen Victoria hired a detective”?

These seem semantically parallel. Yet the two-tier account must treat them **disanalogously**:

- In the Holmes case, existential generalization is blocked.
- In the Queen Victoria case, existential generalization seems fine, because Victoria is straightforwardly referred to. (p. 144)

Why this undercuts creationism

One of creationism's original selling points was that fictional names have referents and can therefore support cross-context identity claims. But if the theory blocks exportation from "true according to the fiction" contexts in the Holmes case, then it loses some of the very explanatory power that motivated it. (p. 144)

4. Salmon's Hard-Line Version: Accept the Cost (p. 144)

Nathan Salmon represents the more uncompromising creationist option. He accepts that:

- Holmes is a real abstract artifact.
- The Canon is indeed **massively false** about him.
- Yet the same name is imported from fiction into reality, allowing later discourse to concern the very same abstract object. (p. 144)

Hayaki suggests this may be the least unstable form of creationism: rather than denying ordinary semantic appearances, it accepts the full counterintuitive burden. But that burden remains heavy.

5. Second Difficulty: Aboutness (pp. 144–147)

Hayaki then turns from truth-in-fiction to **aboutness**.

At first, the following all seem true:

- The Canon is about Sherlock Holmes.
- The Canon is about a brilliant detective.
- The Canon is about Queen Victoria.

But Hayaki argues that "about" is an **intensional** context, not a simple extensional relation. (pp. 145–146)

Why this matters

If creationism says Holmes is a real abstract object, one might infer:

- There exists an x such that $x = \text{Sherlock Holmes}$ and the Canon is about x .

But this seems wrong, because the Canon is not about **Sherlock-Holmes-the-abstract-object**. It is about Holmes *as a man*, detective, friend of Watson, investigator of crimes. Yet there is no

such concrete Holmes. So creationism appears to force a strained reading of “about”: the fiction is allegedly about an abstract artifact, even though nothing in the fiction concerns abstract artifacts of that sort. (p. 145)

Hayaki pushes this point with nearby relations such as **appearing in** a fiction. Queen Victoria, London, Bertillon, and Holmes all “appear” in the Canon. But if Holmes is an abstract object, then saying that **Holmes-the-abstract-object appears in the Canon** sounds nearly as awkward as saying the Canon is about him *qua* abstract object. (p. 146)

Core tension

Creationists now face a dilemma:

- Treat sentence (3) (“The Canon is about Sherlock Holmes”) like sentence (5) (“The Canon is about Queen Victoria”), and accept that the Canon is about a real abstract object.
- Or treat (3) more like sentence (4) (“The Canon is about a brilliant private detective”), where no existential import follows.

Either route weakens creationism. (pp. 146–147)

6. Comparison with Rival Theories (pp. 147–148)

Hayaki closes by comparing creationism with two other families of views.

Possibilism

On possibilism, Holmes is a **nonactual but possible** object. The Canon is true at certain possible worlds where Holmes exists and is a detective. This avoids the mystery: Holmes really is a detective at those worlds, just as Queen Victoria really does the relevant things at those worlds. Aboutness also becomes easier to explain. Hayaki says possibilism is **unaffected** by the problems she raises. (p. 147)

Meinongianism

Meinongianism says fictional objects are in some sense **real but nonexistent**. Some versions resemble creationism in leaving Holmes with few ordinary properties; others, like Zalta’s encoding/exemplifying distinction or Priest’s impossible/open worlds, offer different machinery. Hayaki suggests some Meinongian views are vulnerable, but the problems are **most acute for creationism**. (pp. 147–148)